



Rallying symbol

The Viet Minh adopted the red flag with a gold star as its banner in 1940. It became the official flag of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam when Ho Chi Minh proclaimed the country's independence in 1945.

Searching for allies

The Viet Minh knew that the key to the future lay in the attitude of the wartime Allies. Ho Chi Minh modeled his independence declaration upon the American Declaration of Independence of 1776 in the hope of winning the backing of the United States. No mention was made of communism or social revolution.

The American government, although opposed to colonialism, was anxious to maintain good relations with France and declined to intervene on behalf of the Viet Minh. The Allies decided that, in order to accept the surrender of Japanese troops in Vietnam, the British army would occupy the country south of the 16th parallel and China would occupy the area to the north. No friends to French colonialism, the Chinese allowed Ho Chi Minh's government to remain in place; the British, however, saw it as their duty to facilitate the restoration of French rule.

Aided by the British, French administrators and troops returned to southern Vietnam in October 1945. Quashing Viet Minh resistance, they regained control of Saigon and other major towns, although guerrillas continued to dominate the countryside. After lengthy negotiations, the Chinese agreed to allow the French to return north of the 16th parallel, and the first troops under General Philippe Leclerc landed at Haiphong in March 1946. Ho's government, lacking international support, decided to compromise with France, which was proposing self-government within a French-ruled Indochina Federation.

Ho Chi Minh traveled to France for negotiations at the Fontainebleau Conference in July 1946, in an attempt to seek an agreement, despite French determination to block full independence for a united Vietnam.